

Baked Ziti with Italian Sausage and Garlic Sourdough Bread

Status: Stage 1 Draft
Weekly folder: `weekly-plans/2026/week-28/`
Category: Pasta
Source or inspiration: Next-week family menu idea
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Planning Summary

- Servings: 6
- Estimated prep time: 20 minutes
- Estimated cook time: 40 minutes
- Protein: Italian sausage
- Cuisine or flavor direction: Italian-American comfort food, tomato sauce, cheesy pasta
- Best day to cook: Saturday
- Perishability notes: Sausage and dairy should stay cold. This meal has strong leftovers.

Equipment

- Large pot
- Large skillet
- 9x13 baking dish
- Mixing bowl
- Foil
- Baking sheet

Ingredients

Assume nothing is on hand. Include quantities for everything used.

Quantity	Ingredient	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Notes
1 lb	Ziti pasta	Dry ziti	Penne or rigatoni	Main pasta
1 1/2 lb	Italian sausage	Mild bulk sausage	Links with casings removed	Main protein
1 tbsp	Olive oil	Extra-virgin or regular	Neutral oil	If sausage is lean
1 small	Yellow onion	Diced	1/2 large onion	Sauce
4 cloves	Garlic	Fresh minced	1 tsp garlic powder	Sauce
32 oz	Marinara sauce	Jarred, good-quality	Homemade tomato sauce	Sauce
14.5 oz	Crushed tomatoes	Canned	Diced tomatoes, crushed by hand	Sauce
1 tsp	Italian seasoning	Dried blend	Dried oregano plus basil	Sauce
1/2 tsp	Kosher salt	Kosher	Fine sea salt	Sauce, adjust to taste

Quantity	Ingredient	Preferred version/type	Acceptable alternatives	Notes
1/4 tsp	Black pepper	Freshly ground	Ground black pepper	Sauce
15 oz	Ricotta cheese	Whole milk	Part-skim	Cheese layer
1 large	Egg	Large	Skip for looser ricotta	Cheese layer
2 cups	Mozzarella cheese	Shredded low-moisture	Italian cheese blend	Topping and filling
1/2 cup	Parmesan cheese	Grated	Pecorino Romano	Divided
2 tbsp	Fresh parsley	Chopped	Basil	Finish
1 loaf	Sourdough bread	Crusty loaf	Italian bread	Garlic bread
6 tbsp	Butter	Unsalted, softened	Salted, reduce added salt	Garlic bread
3 cloves	Garlic	Fresh minced	1 tsp garlic powder	Garlic bread
1 tbsp	Fresh parsley	Chopped	Dried parsley	Garlic bread
1/4 tsp	Kosher salt	Kosher	Fine sea salt	Garlic bread

Basic Instructions

1. Heat oven to 375 degrees F. Boil ziti in salted water for 2 minutes less than the package says. Drain.
2. Brown sausage in a skillet, breaking it into small pieces. Add olive oil only if the pan is dry.
3. Add onion and cook until softened, 4 to 5 minutes. Add garlic for 30 seconds.
4. Stir in marinara, crushed tomatoes, Italian seasoning, salt, and pepper. Simmer 8 to 10 minutes.
5. Mix ricotta, egg, 1 cup mozzarella, 1/4 cup Parmesan, and parsley in a bowl.
6. Combine pasta with most of the sauce. Layer half the pasta in a 9x13 dish, dollop with ricotta mixture, then add remaining pasta. Top with remaining sauce, 1 cup mozzarella, and 1/4 cup Parmesan.
7. Cover with foil and bake 20 minutes. Uncover and bake 10 to 15 minutes more, until bubbling and browned in spots. Rest 10 minutes before serving.
8. For garlic sourdough, mix softened butter, garlic, parsley, and salt. Spread on sliced sourdough and bake on a sheet pan for 8 to 10 minutes, until toasted.

Notes

- What might need testing: Whether the family prefers more sauce or more cheese.
- Possible substitutions: Use hot Italian sausage for more heat, or half mild and half hot.
- Prep-ahead ideas: Assemble ziti earlier Saturday and refrigerate. Add 10 to 15 minutes to covered bake time if cold from the fridge.
- Family preference concerns: This is heavier than the rice bowls, so serve with a simple salad next time if desired.

Review Link

Review file: